Q+A

FROM THE HEART

Fresh off a BAFTA win, Manipuri film Boong gets a theatrical rerelease. Writer-director ***Lakshmipriya Devi Kumar*** *hopes Indian audiences will take to the film*

Q. You have been a leading assistant director [AD] for nearly two decades. How did your debut feature come about?

I never wanted to direct. I only wanted to write. Because the story that came to me was that of this child called Boong, I wasn't going to let anyone else direct it. I did have other ideas before, but they were dishonest. It has to come from the heart.

Q. Tell us about the experience of shooting in Moreh in Manipur.

It was tough finding a crew. People had functions to go to, a daily routine that included playing football, walking, working for a few hours and resting. Those who were on the project and passionate about it stuck around till the end. We shot with the amazing cooperation of the Manipuri people.

Q. For many, the film is also a beautiful representation of Manipur. You are a Meitei filmmaker. The lead, the child actor, is a Kuki. Are you hopeful that the film brings some sense of healing?

I hope so. We [Manipuris] have been troubled and ignored since 1949. Because of social media, more than before, people know that we are having an ongoing crisis.

Q. You have put Manipuri cinema on the global map and in the mainstream. Is there a sense of responsibility to tell Manipuri stories?

I follow one simple rule: hear everyone out, listen only to yourself. Only when I feel I have a story to tell, wherever it is from, I will tell it. I don't think I need to be a flag-bearer for Manipuri cinema. I don't take myself that seriously.

—with ***Suhani Singh***



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